DAILY AI BRIEFING · LEARN ONE THING + WHAT MOVED

Keeping up with the AIs

Microsoft joins the decision-model race, and Cloudflare buys Deno

Issue #12 | Sun, 11 Oct 2026 | ☕ ~8 min read

⚡ **If you only have one minute**

1. **Microsoft launched Decision-1**, a small model that picks answers instead of writing them, at **$0.042 per million input tokens and free output**. It's the latest big name in the "decision model" race.
2. **Cloudflare is buying Deno.** The Deno runtime gets one more year of fixes; **Deno Deploy shuts down in about six months**.
3. **Part 1 is picking the right model for the job:** the biggest model is rarely the right default for every task.

Today in three numbers

$0.042
per million input tokens for **Microsoft-Decision-1**; output is free

6 months
until **Deno Deploy** shuts down, per Deno's announcement

1,222
people in a **Berkeley-led study** on what 10 minutes of AI help does to persistence

PART 1 Learn one thing

🎛️ Picking the right model for the job

4 MIN READ | MODULE 2 · GETTING GREAT RESULTS

Every AI lab now sells a family of models, from tiny and cheap to huge and slow. Picking well is mostly about matching the model to the task, not finding "the best" one.

Every model choice trades off three things: **quality** (does it get the answer right?), **speed** (how long until the first word, and the last?) and **cost** (what you pay per million tokens). You can rarely max out all three. **Bigger models are usually smarter, but slower and pricier.**

Analogy: you don't book a flight from Andheri to Bandra. An auto gets you there faster and for a fraction of the price. For Mumbai to Delhi, though, the flight wins easily. **The right vehicle depends on the trip.** Same with models: a tiny model can sort support tickets all day, while a frontier model earns its price on a gnarly refactor.

Two sensible ways to start

🛵 Efficiency-first

- Start with the **smallest, cheapest** model
- Test it on your real tasks
- Upgrade only where it **visibly fails**

`Good for: prototypes, high volume, tight latency`

VS

🚀 Capability-first

- Start with a **frontier** model
- Get the quality right first
- Then **lower effort or step down** to cut cost

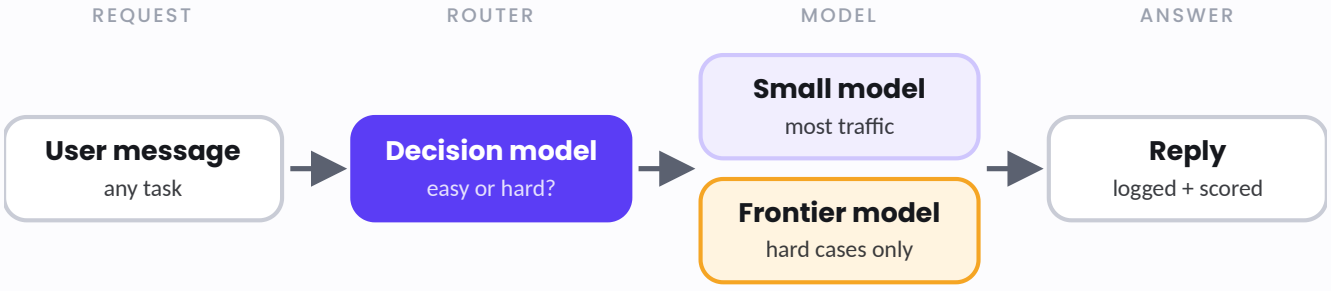
`Good for: hard reasoning, coding agents`

Both approaches are from Anthropic's 'Choosing a model' guide. Either way, the step that matters is testing on your own prompts and data.

The second dial: effort. Many models now have a reasoning "effort" setting (low, medium, high and so on). Anthropic's docs say **tuning effort is often a better lever than switching models**. OpenAI's guide says something similar: compare settings on the same inputs and keep **"the lightest setting that meets your quality bar."** (Claude Docs) (OpenAI)

The third option: use more than one. Real apps often route each request to the cheapest model that can handle it, so most tokens bill at the low rate:

A simple model router



Illustrative. Anthropic's docs describe two versions: a cheap 'executor' that escalates hard calls to an 'advisor', and an 'orchestrator' that hands bulk work to cheaper 'workers'.

Why now? Model families keep splitting into more tiers, plus a new class of **decision models** that only pick answers (see Part 2). On OpenRouter's usage rankings, cheap "Flash" models currently sit at the top by tokens processed. **There, at least, most traffic isn't going to the flagships.** (OpenRouter)

📖 Jargon buster

- **Tier:** a model's size class in its family (think Haiku / Sonnet / Opus, or Luna / Sol / Astra).
- **Latency:** how long you wait. "Time to first token" matters most for chat.
- **Eval:** a fixed set of your own test cases with known good answers, used to compare models fairly.
- **Router:** code (or a small model) that decides which model handles each request.

🧪 Try it in 10 minutes

- **No code:** take one task you do daily (say, summarising a long email). Run it through a **small and a large model** from the same family, side by side. Would you notice the difference? If not, the small one wins.
- **Some code:** write down **10 real inputs** and what a good answer looks like. Run the script below against two models. That's your first eval.

🛠️ For devs: a 15-line model bake-off

```
import time
from anthropic import Anthropic
client = Anthropic()

cases = [("Refund not received after 7 days", "billing"),
         ("App crashes on login", "bug")]  # add ~20 real ones

for model in ["claude-haiku-5-5", "claude-sonnet-5-5"]:
    right, t0 = 0, time.time()
    for text, want in cases:
        r = client.messages.create(model=model, max_tokens=5,
            messages=[{"role": "user", "content":
              f"Label as billing, bug or other. One word.\n\n{text}"}])
        right += r.content[0].text.strip().lower() == want
    print(model, f"{right}/{len(cases)}", f"{time.time()-t0:.1f}s")
```

Gotchas: public benchmarks measure *someone else's* task, so **your eval beats any leaderboard**. Track cost per *task*, not per token: a cheaper model that needs three retries isn't cheaper. And re-run your eval when a provider ships a new version, because **the ranking can flip**.

🔗 GO DEEPER

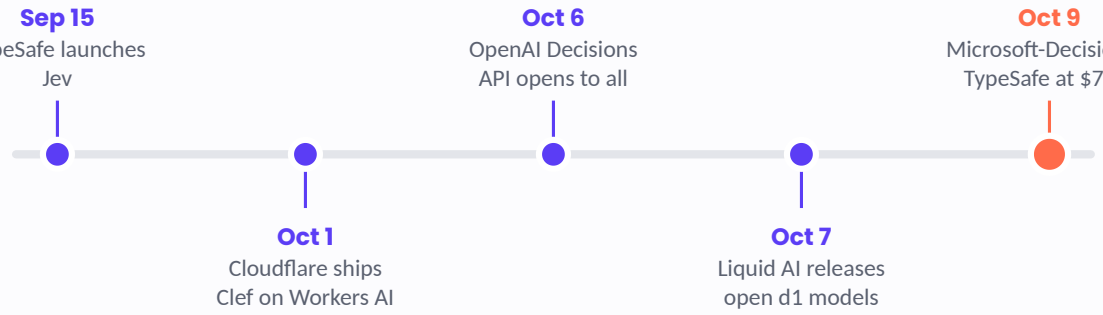
- **Choosing the right model** (Anthropic). Efficiency-first vs capability-first, effort levels and multi-model patterns.
- **Model selection** (OpenAI). Which GPT-6 tier and reasoning effort fits which kind of work.
- **LLM leaderboard** (Artificial Analysis). Independent intelligence, speed, latency and cost-per-task numbers for 250+ models.
- **LLM rankings** (OpenRouter). What developers are actually spending tokens on, by task category.

PART 2

What moved in AI

7 min read · Covering Friday and Saturday. Microsoft joined the rush to models that decide rather than chat, a well-loved JavaScript runtime found a new home, and a study suggests asking AI for answers makes us quit sooner.

Four weeks of the decision-model rush



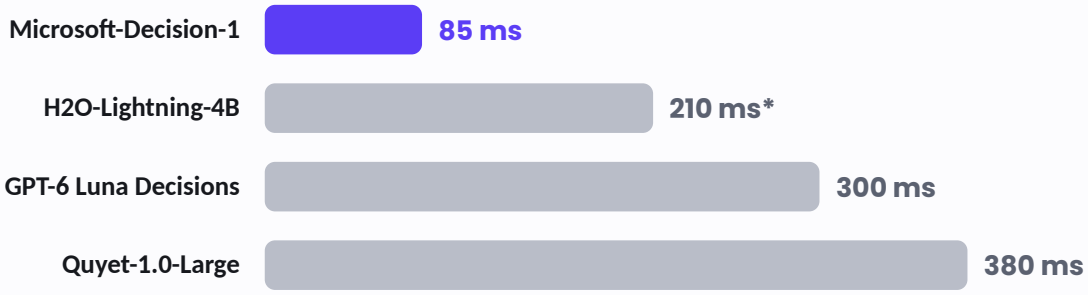
Dates from Crypto Briefing, Cloudflare, Let's Data Science, Liquid AI and OpenRouter. Earlier steps covered in Issues #1, #4, #10 and #11.

Top story 1 · Microsoft's Decision-1: an AI that picks, not chats

BIG DEAL DECISION MODELS TRY IT

What happened. Microsoft released **Microsoft-Decision-1**, a model for routing, classification, checking and agent guardrails. You give it a question and a fixed set of options; it returns **a calibrated probability for each option**, as JSON, in one call. No essay. (MarkTechPost)

Median latency, Microsoft's own chart (lower is faster)



Vendor-run numbers as reported by MarkTechPost; rivals' figures use an adjusted JevBench median. *H2O.ai disputes its number and says its measured median is 29 ms.

The details that matter:

- **Price: $0.042 per million input tokens, and output is free.** OpenAI's equivalent Decisions endpoint charges $0.10 per million input. (OpenRouter) (Let's Data Science)
- **Under the hood:** it's **post-trained from Alibaba's open Qwen3.5-9B**, text-only, with a 32K-token context. Weights are **not** released; it's API-only via Microsoft Foundry and OpenRouter.
- **Microsoft claims** 83.5% accuracy across 36 benchmarks and 147,137 questions, ahead of GPT-6 Luna Decisions at 79.4%. Its answers flipped on **only 1.3%** of reworded or shuffled questions. **All vendor-run**;

independent JevBench results are pending.

- **Not for:** chat, summaries, translation, or being the **sole decider** on credit, jobs, housing, health or legal matters.

Why it matters. When Microsoft, OpenAI, Cloudflare, Perplexity and a $7.5B startup all ship the same kind of product within a month, it's a category. **The plumbing of AI apps (routing, tagging, "is this safe?") is moving off chat models** onto cheaper, faster specialists.

WHO SHOULD CARE 🙋 Everyone ●○○○○ 🎨 Vibe coders ●●●○○ 🛠️ Developers ●●●●●
🔥 Hype level ●●●○○

👀 **Should you care?** If your app asks a big model **"which category is this?"** thousands of times a day, yes. This could cut that bill sharply. If you only chat with AI, not yet.

🛠️ **For devs: it's not a chat endpoint**

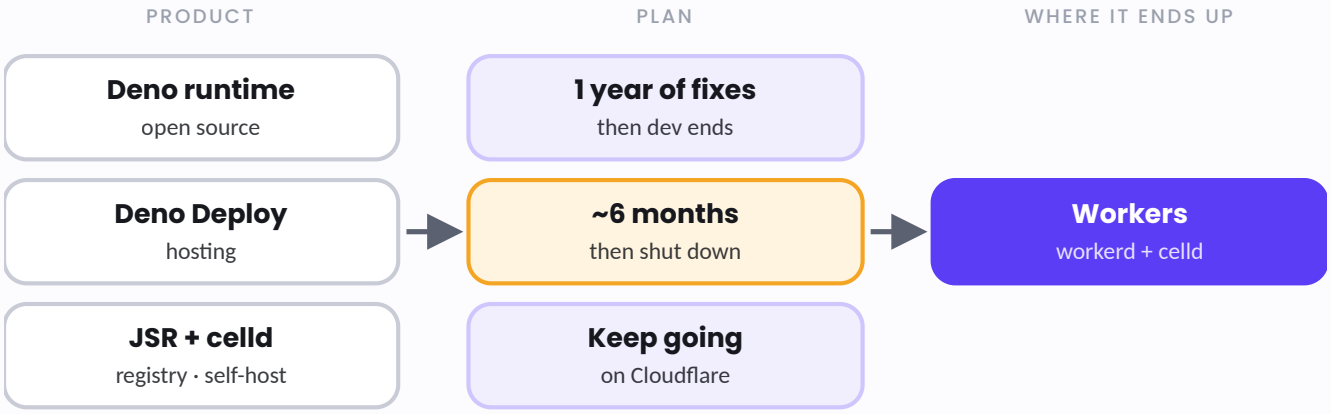
On OpenRouter it runs on the **Decisions API, not chat completions**, so your usual chat SDK call won't work. Always include a **"cannot tell"** option and set your own probability threshold for when to escalate to a human or a bigger model.

Top story 2 · Cloudflare buys Deno, with a deadline

DEV TOOLS ACQUISITION

What happened. Cloudflare is acquiring **Deno**, the company behind the JavaScript/TypeScript runtime created by Node.js inventor **Ryan Dahl**. The whole team joins Cloudflare to work on **Workers**, its serverless platform. Terms weren't disclosed. (BetaNews)

What happens to each Deno product



From Deno's announcement as quoted by BetaNews and DEV Community. The runtime stays open source, so the community could fork it.

The details that matter:

- **Deno runtime:** monthly bug-fix and security releases **for one more year**, then official development ends. It stays open source.
- **Deno Deploy:** runs for **about six months**, then shuts down. Paying customers get help moving to Workers.

- **JSR**, the JavaScript package registry, keeps running, with its servers moving to Cloudflare.
- **The real plan:** merge **celld**, Deno's self-hostable take on Workers, into **workerd**, Cloudflare's open-source Workers runtime, so you can run Workers-style apps **on your own servers**.

Why it matters. Lots of AI demos and agent backends run on edge runtimes like Deno Deploy and Workers. One option just disappeared, and **"run Workers anywhere" just got a big push.**

WHO SHOULD CARE 🙋 Everyone ●○○○○ 🎨 Vibe coders ●●○○○ 🛠️ Developers ●●●●○
🔥 Hype level ●●○○○

👀 **Should you care?** If anything of yours runs on **Deno Deploy**, yes: put the migration on your calendar now, not in month five. If you only use Node, this barely touches you.

🛠️ **For devs: the rough migration map**

`Deno.serve()` becomes a Worker `fetch` handler. **Deno KV** becomes Workers KV (simple reads) or Durable Objects (when you need transactions); that's the main design choice. `Deno.cron()` becomes a Cron Trigger. Most npm dependencies carry over. (DEV Community)

Top story 3 · AI answers make people quit sooner

RESEARCH VIBE CODERS

What happened. A UC Berkeley-led team ran three randomised experiments with **1,222 people** online. One group could ask ChatGPT for help on fraction problems or SAT-style reading questions; then, after about 10 minutes, **the AI was taken away**. Their accuracy dropped, and they **skipped more questions** than people who never had AI. (EurekAlert)

Solve rate after the AI was removed



Experiments 1 (n=354) and 3 (n=201), from the paper's project page. Skip rates rose too: 11% to 20% on fractions, 1% to 8% on reading.

The details that matter:

- **It's how you use it.** In the replication, **61% of AI users asked for direct answers**, and they showed the biggest drops. People who asked for **hints or clarifications showed no significant harm.** (Project page)
- **Peer-reviewed** at COLM, with co-authors from CMU, MIT, Oxford and UCLA. **Limits:** short tasks, one session. Lead author Brian Christian wants AI to act **more like a tutor**; long-term effects **weren't tested**.

Why it matters. Vibe coding is built on asking for answers. This doesn't say "stop", but it hints that **how you prompt shapes what you can still do on your own**.

WHO SHOULD CARE 🙋 Everyone ●●●●○ 🎨 Vibe coders ●●●●● 🛠️ Developers ●●●○○

🔥 Hype level ●●○○○

👀 **Should you care?** If you're learning to code with AI, **yes**. Try "give me a hint, not the fix" on the next bug. It's slower today and better for you next month.

⚡ Quick hits

🧩 A frozen LLM clears ARC-AGI-3's public games.

Memento 3 improves a written "rulebook", not the model, and maxes out all 25 public games. The private set is the real bar. (arXiv)

🔎 Perplexity open-sources search embeddings.

pplx-embed-v2-late (0.6B and 9B, MIT licence) handles text and image retrieval; the 9B self-reports 92.4% on MADQA. (MarkTechPost)

💻 JetBrains' small coding model.

Mellum2.1 (Apache 2.0, 12B total, 2.5B active) has GGUF builds from 7 GB for Ollama or LM Studio. (MarkTechPost)

📱 22 AI agents you can text.

TechCrunch rounds up assistants living in iMessage, WhatsApp or SMS. **No India availability mentioned.** (TechCrunch)

⚙️ $250M to build tiny machines from code.

Jeff Holden's **Atomic Machines** left stealth; first product: a fast power switch for **800-volt AI data centres**. (The Next Web)

🗓️ Coming up.

TechCrunch Disrupt: 13–15 Oct. 64GB DGX Spark: 23 Oct. Mistral Large 4 weights: 27 Oct. ARC Prize deadline: 2 Nov.

🎯 One thing to try today: downgrade one task

Pick one thing you always send to your **biggest** model. Run it on the **smallest** one in the same family five times. If you can't tell the difference, you just found free money.

🧠 Pop quiz: 30 seconds, no Googling

1. What does Anthropic say is often a better lever than switching models?

A. A longer prompt
B. Tuning the effort setting
C. Higher temperature

2. What does Microsoft-Decision-1 return?

A. A probability for each option
B. A paragraph of reasoning
C. An image

3. In the Berkeley study, which AI users showed no significant harm?

A. Those who asked for answers
B. Those who asked for hints
C. Nobody

Answers (no peeking): 1. B: effort trades smarts for speed and cost in one model · 2. A: it scores fixed choices instead of writing text · 3. B: direct-answer users had the biggest drops

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